

# Thailand — Chiang Mai & the North

## 7 - 12 September 2026

Haris Haikal & Aina Izzaty · one hotel for five nights, day trips out, no driver to arrange  
Green season: waterfalls at full flow, terraces vivid green, low season prices.

### The Six Days

| DAY   | DATE        | SHAPE            | WHERE                   | DRIVING |
|-------|-------------|------------------|-------------------------|---------|
| Day 1 | Mon, 7 Sep  | Fly + city       | Old City, Nimman cafés  | none    |
| Day 2 | Tue, 8 Sep  | Mountain day     | Doi Inthanon            | ~4h     |
| Day 3 | Wed, 9 Sep  | Gardens + cafés  | Mae Rim, Bua Tong falls | ~2h     |
| Day 4 | Thu, 10 Sep | Long day out     | Chiang Rai temples      | ~6h     |
| Day 5 | Fri, 11 Sep | Temple + markets | Doi Suthep, Warorot     | ~1h     |
| Day 6 | Sat, 12 Sep | Fly home         | CNX → KUL               | 20 min  |

### Book Tonight, In This Order

- 1 Ask Malaysia Airlines to reroute, don't cancel**  
MAS runs two of the three daily KUL–Chiang Mai flights (MH772 09:50→11:40, MH792 11:50→13:40). If they cancel CGK, ask to be moved onto their Chiang Mai service instead of refunded. **+60 3-7843-3000**
- 2 Flights KUL → CNX on 7 Sept, and the return on 12 Sept**  
8 flights a week on the route: MH772, MH792, and AirAsia AK856 (13:30→15:10). 2h 40m.
- 3 TDAC — Thailand Digital Arrival Card**  
Mandatory for every entry, filed online at [tdac.immigration.go.th](https://tdac.immigration.go.th) before you arrive. The Thai equivalent of the Indonesian e-CD — don't skip it.
- 4 Hotel — five nights, one place**  
Old City or Nimman. No hotel switch in this version, so unpack once.
- 5 Two day tours with car + driver**  
Doi Inthanon (Day 2) and Chiang Rai (Day 4). Hotel desk, Klook or GetYourGuide. Book both tonight — they leave early.
- 6 Cancel or move the Bandung bookings**  
Holiday Inn Pasteur, Swiss-Belresort Dago, Fairfield CGK — ask for a waiver citing the airport closure. Message Kiki.
- 7 Insurance, eSIM, offline maps**  
Re-issue the insurance for Thailand and keep the Bandung cancellation paperwork for the claim. Signal is fine in the city, patchy on Doi Inthanon.

### Good To Know

|                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Visa</b><br>Visa-free for Malaysians — the 60-day exemption still applies on 7 Sept (30 days from 15 Sept, irrelevant for 5 nights).              | <b>Money</b><br>Thai baht. Cards fine in the city; cash for markets, temples, park entry.                  | <b>Getting around</b><br>Grab and Bolt everywhere; songthaews ~30–40 THB a hop. The two mountain days come with a driver. |
| <b>Weather</b><br>Green season: ~33°C, humid, ~18 rainy days in September. Showers come late afternoon or overnight — mornings are the clear window. | <b>Temple dress</b><br>Shoulders and knees covered at every temple, both of you. A light scarf handles it. | <b>Why here</b><br>Waterfalls at full flow, terraces at their greenest, and the quietest, cheapest month of the year.     |

Flight out: \_\_\_\_\_ Flight home: \_\_\_\_\_ Booking ref: \_\_\_\_\_  
 Doi Inthanon tour: \_\_\_\_\_ Chiang Rai tour: \_\_\_\_\_ *Checked 6 Sept 2026 — confirm fares and availability.*

DAY 1

# Fly to Chiang Mai + Old City

Monday, 7 September

START  
09.50 from KLIA

FINISH  
~21.00

SLEEP  
Chiang Mai (all 5 nights)

**Outfit:** Summer outfit — but carry a scarf/shawl for the temples

| TIME                   | WHERE                                                                                                       | HOW LONG | NOTES                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>09.50</b>           | <b>KUL → CNX — Malaysia Airlines MH772</b><br>KLIA                                                          | 2h 40m   | Lands 11.40. MH792 (11.50→13.40) and AirAsia AK856 (13.30→15.10) are the other same-day options. Thailand is <b>1 hour behind Malaysia</b> . |
| <b>~12.30</b>          | <b>Check in — Old City or Nimman</b><br>Chiang Mai                                                          | 1h       | One hotel for the whole trip. Old City = temples on your doorstep; Nimman = cafés and a younger feel. Both fine.                             |
| <b>~14.00</b>          | <b>Wat Phra Singh + Wat Chedi Luang</b><br>Old City, inside the moat<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 2h       | The two big ones, 10 minutes apart on foot. <b>Shoulders and knees covered</b> — this applies to both of you at every temple.                |
| <b>~15 min by Grab</b> |                                                                                                             |          |                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>~16.30</b>          | <b>Nimmanhaemin — One Nimman + a café</b><br>Nimmanhaemin Road<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>       | 2h       | Chiang Mai's café district: Ristr8to, Graph, Akha Ama. This is the Braga-and-Kopi-Toko-Djawa slot.                                           |
| <b>~19.00</b>          | <b>Dinner — khao soi, then the Night Bazaar</b><br>Chang Klan Road                                          | 2h       | Khao soi is the northern dish to try first. Night Bazaar is touristy but good for a first evening.                                           |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Easy first day on purpose — one flight, no long transfer, unlike the Bandung and Hanoi versions.
- Grab and Bolt both work here. Songthaews (red trucks) are ~30-40 THB a hop in the city — flag one down and say where.
- Green season: showers tend to come late afternoon or overnight. Keep a light rain shell in the day bag.

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DAY 2

# Doi Inthanon — the roof of Thailand

Tuesday, 8 September

|                |                  |                     |
|----------------|------------------|---------------------|
| START<br>07.30 | FINISH<br>~18.30 | SLEEP<br>Chiang Mai |
|----------------|------------------|---------------------|

**Outfit:** Emerald denim casual — green terraces, cool mountain air

| TIME                                                      | WHERE                                                                                                                              | HOW LONG | NOTES                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 07.30                                                     | Depart with your booked car + driver                                                                                               | —        | Book a private day tour the night before — hotel desk, Klook or GetYourGuide. This replaces Kiki for the day.                                        |
| DRIVE: Chiang Mai → Doi Inthanon National Park — ~2 hours |                                                                                                                                    |          |                                                                                                                                                      |
| ~09.30                                                    | <b>Twin Royal Pagodas + gardens</b><br>Doi Inthanon, 2,565 m<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                                | 1.5h     | The King and Queen pagodas with terraced gardens between them. <b>Cold and windy up here</b> — 15–20°C, bring the jacket you packed for Kawah Putih. |
| ~11.15                                                    | <b>Ang Ka nature trail + summit point</b><br>Doi Inthanon summit<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                            | 45 min   | Short boardwalk through mossy cloud forest. Thailand's highest point is a marker, not a view — the trail is the good part.                           |
| ~30 min down the mountain                                 |                                                                                                                                    |          |                                                                                                                                                      |
| ~12.30                                                    | <b>Ban Mae Klang Luang — rice terraces + Karen coffee village</b><br>Doi Inthanon foothills<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 2.5h     | Vivid green terraces in September, hill-tribe village, coffee grown on the slope. Lunch here at a terrace restaurant.                                |
| ~20 min                                                   |                                                                                                                                    |          |                                                                                                                                                      |
| ~15.30                                                    | <b>Wachirathan Waterfall</b><br>Doi Inthanon National Park<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                                  | 1h       | Thunderous in green season and throws spray a long way — this is the wettest you'll get all trip, which is the fun of it.                            |
| DRIVE: back to Chiang Mai — ~2 hours                      |                                                                                                                                    |          |                                                                                                                                                      |
| ~18.30                                                    | <b>Back in the city — dinner nearby</b>                                                                                            | —        | Long day. Keep dinner close to the hotel.                                                                                                            |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Longest driving day of the trip, ~4 hours total — this is the Ciwidey day of the Thailand plan.
- National park entry is charged per person at the gate; your driver will stop for it.
- Winding mountain road — the motion-sickness tablets from your checklist earn their place today.

DAY 3

# Mae Rim valley — gardens, cafés, sticky waterfall

Wednesday, 9 September

START  
09.00FINISH  
~19.30SLEEP  
Chiang Mai**Outfit:** Cream elegant — botanic gardens and forest cafés

| TIME                            | WHERE                                                                                                         | HOW LONG | NOTES                                                                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>09.00</b>                    | <b>Depart north into the Mae Sa valley</b>                                                                    | —        | Grab works for this, but a half-day car is easier with several stops.                                                                                               |
| <b>~40 min</b>                  |                                                                                                               |          |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>~09.45</b>                   | <b>Queen Sirikit Botanic Garden</b><br>Mae Rim district<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                | 2.5h     | Glasshouses, orchids and a canopy walkway through the treetops. The elegant-outfit location of the trip.                                                            |
| <b>~30 min</b>                  |                                                                                                               |          |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>~13.00</b>                   | <b>Lunch at a valley café</b><br>Mae Rim / Mae Sa valley                                                      | 1.5h     | The Giant (a treehouse café) or Fern Forest. Chiang Mai's answer to Lawangwangi and Congo.                                                                          |
| <b>~40 min north</b>            |                                                                                                               |          |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>~15.30</b>                   | <b>Bua Tong Sticky Waterfalls</b><br>Si Lanna National Park, Mae Taeng<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 2h       | Limestone falls you can genuinely walk <i>up</i> — the rock grips your feet. Free entry. Bring a change of clothes: this is the Cibuni of this trip, minus the mud. |
| <b>~1 hour back to the city</b> |                                                                                                               |          |                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>~18.30</b>                   | <b>Dinner in Nimman</b><br>Nimmanhaemin                                                                       | 1.5h     |                                                                                                                                                                     |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Mon Jam's famous flower fields are a cool-season thing (Nov-Feb). In September the valley is green and misty instead — beautiful, but manage expectations.
- Sticky Waterfalls: sandals or shoes you don't mind soaking, and the towel from the packing list.
- This is the easy-driving day: everything is within 40 minutes of the city.

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DAY 4

# Chiang Rai — White, Blue and Black

Thursday, 10 September

START  
07.30 sharp

FINISH  
~20.30

SLEEP  
Chiang Mai

**Outfit:** Cute pink & white — the temples are the colour palette

| TIME                                               | WHERE                                                                                            | HOW LONG | NOTES                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 07.30                                              | Depart on the Chiang Rai day tour                                                                | —        | A ~13-hour day. Book a small-group or private tour; it runs to a fixed timetable.                                                        |
| DRIVE: Chiang Mai → Chiang Rai — ~3 hours each way |                                                                                                  |          |                                                                                                                                          |
| ~10.30                                             | <b>Wat Rong Khun — the White Temple</b><br>Chiang Rai<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>     | 1.5h     | All white and mirrored glass. The most photographed building in northern Thailand — go straight to the bridge before the coaches arrive. |
| ~12.15                                             | <b>Lunch in Chiang Rai</b><br>Chiang Rai town                                                    | 1h       |                                                                                                                                          |
| ~13.30                                             | <b>Wat Rong Suea Ten — the Blue Temple</b><br>Chiang Rai<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>  | 1h       | Electric blue and gold inside. Pink and white against that blue is the photo of the day.                                                 |
| ~15.00                                             | <b>Baan Dam — the Black House</b><br>Nang Lae, Chiang Rai<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 1.5h     | The dark counterpoint to the White Temple: an artist's compound of black timber halls. Odd and memorable.                                |
| DRIVE: back to Chiang Mai — ~3 hours               |                                                                                                  |          |                                                                                                                                          |
| ~20.30                                             | Back at the hotel                                                                                | —        | Late finish. Keep tomorrow gentle.                                                                                                       |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- The one genuinely long day — 6 hours in the car for three of the north's signature sights. Worth it, but do not add anything else to today.
- Snacks and water in the day bag; stops are at the tour's discretion.
- If the forecast is heavy all day, swap this with Day 5 — the temples are better in dry light.

DAY 5

# Doi Suthep + city, markets and massage

Friday, 11 September

START  
08.30FINISH  
~21.00SLEEP  
Chiang Mai
**Outfit:** Smart casual — temple-appropriate again

| TIME              | WHERE                                                                                                                | HOW LONG | NOTES                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>08.30</b>      | <b>Wat Phra That Doi Suthep</b><br>Doi Suthep, 30 min from the Old City<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>       | 2h       | Chiang Mai's landmark temple on the mountain. Go early — the cloud rolls in later and the crowds arrive with it. 300 steps up, or the funicular. |
| ~30 min back down |                                                                                                                      |          |                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>~11.30</b>     | <b>Lunch + coffee in the Old City</b><br>Old City                                                                    | 1.5h     |                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>~13.30</b>     | <b>Warorot Market</b><br>Wichayanon Road, by the river<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                        | 1.5h     | Where locals shop: dried fruit, northern sausage, textiles, chilli pastes. This is the Kartika Sari slot — souvenirs and edible gifts.           |
| ~10 min           |                                                                                                                      |          |                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>~15.30</b>     | <b>Wua Lai silver street + handicrafts</b><br>Wua Lai Road, south of the moat<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 1.5h     | Silverwork, lacquer, Lanna crafts. Sunday walking street runs here — you'll miss it, but the shops are open daily.                               |
| <b>~17.30</b>     | <b>Thai massage</b><br>Old City                                                                                      | 1.5h     | Two hours of Thai or oil massage costs less than a taxi ride home. Book a slot mid-afternoon.                                                    |
| <b>~19.30</b>     | <b>Farewell dinner</b><br>Old City or riverside<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a>                               | 1.5h     | Riverside restaurants on the Ping are the nicer end. Pack tonight.                                                                               |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Everything today is 10–30 minutes apart by Grab. No tour needed.
- Doi Suthep is an active temple — the strictest dress code of the trip. Cover shoulders and knees, shoes off inside.
- Leave room in the bags: Warorot and Wua Lai are where the souvenirs actually happen.

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DAY 6

# Fly home

Saturday, 12 September

START

Depends on flight

FINISH

KUL

SLEEP

—

**Outfit:** Comfy travel outfit

| TIME             | WHERE                                                                       | HOW LONG     | NOTES                                                                            |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>08.00</b>     | <b>Breakfast + last café</b><br>Chiang Mai                                  | 1.5h         | The airport is only 15–20 minutes from anywhere in the city, so there's no rush. |
| <b>~10.30</b>    | <b>Checkout → Chiang Mai Airport (CNX)</b><br>~20 min by Grab               | —            | Small, easy airport — international departures are straightforward.              |
| <b>~11.30</b>    | <b>Check-in + immigration</b><br>CNX<br><a href="#">Open in Google Maps</a> | 2h<br>buffer | Standard 2 hours for an international flight.                                    |
| <b>afternoon</b> | <b>CNX → KUL</b>                                                            | ~2h<br>40m   | Confirm your return time when you book the outbound — Malaysia is 1 hour ahead.  |

## NOTES FOR THE DAY

- CNX is the easiest airport exit of any version of this trip — 20 minutes from the hotel.